

Attitudes table, 2026 edition: certification memo

Certified table. 9 of the 18 indicators with a 2024 figure moved over the decade from 2014 to 2024: Too little is being spent on welfare (+13.9 points); Abortion should be possible if the woman wants it for any reason (+13.0 points); A great deal of confidence in the people running medicine (-12.8 points); Use of marijuana should be made legal (+11.7 points); Very happy (-8.5 points); Democrat, including independents close to the Democrats (-7.7 points); Too little is being spent on improving and protecting the environment (+7.5 points); Pretty well satisfied with present financial situation (-4.7 points); No religious preference (+4.7 points). The other 9 updated indicators are not reported as moved. A good idea for older people to share a home with their grown children, Too little is being spent on parks and recreation were not fielded in 2024 and are carried without a change. Neither draft is certified: Research's draft reports 15 indicators as moved and the editor's 12.

The two drafts

Research's draft rebuilt both years on the post stratification weight, as the standard requires, but its sampling errors are those of a simple random sample of the respondents (the square root of $p(1-p)/n$ in each year). The GSS is a stratified multistage sample and its design effects on these items run between about 1.6 and 3.2, so those errors are too small by a fifth to nearly a half. On the design based error, six of the fifteen indicators it reports fall back inside the margin: A person with an incurable disease has the right to end their own life, Favours a police permit before a person can buy a gun, Favours the death penalty for persons convicted of murder, Most people can be trusted, People get ahead by their own hard work, The Bible is the actual word of God. Not certified.

The editor's draft kept the 2014 figures printed in the 2016 edition, which were weighted by WTSSALL, and set 2024 figures on WTSSPS beside them. The sampling errors are design based, but the two years are on different weights, which rule 4 of the standard does not allow: the 2014 figures have to be restated on WTSSPS. The mixed weights add between 0.0 and 1.2 points of spurious change, and three indicators cross the margin on that alone: Favours a police permit before a person can buy a gun, Most people can be trusted, People get ahead by their own hard work. Not certified.

Continuity and restatement

All twenty indicators reproduce the 2016 edition's published figures from the current file under that edition's method (WTSSALL for 2014; WTSSALL with the OVERSAMP weight for 1987), to the published precision and respondent count, so none is held out. The 2016 edition's 2014 figures are restated on WTSSPS for every indicator; 19 of the twenty change at one decimal. The largest restatement is Democrat, including independents close to the Democrats: 44.7 becomes 43.6, -1.2 points.

The first edition column is on WTSSPS alone. The OVERSAMP weight that the 2016 edition applied to 1987 belonged with WTSSALL, which does not adjust for the 1987 Black oversample; WTSSPS already does. With WTSSPS the Black share of the 1987 sample is 11.0 percent, in line with 1988 (11.0 percent on the same weight), while applying OVERSAMP on top of WTSSPS would push it to 4.1 percent and move several 1987 figures by one to two points.

Movers and the closest call

The largest decade change is Too little is being spent on welfare: 19.5 to 33.4 percent, +13.9 points (next, Abortion should be possible if the woman wants it for any reason at +13.0). Since the first edition the largest change is Use of marijuana should be made legal: 17.4 percent in 1987 to 67.0 in 2024, +49.6 points (next, A great deal of confidence in the people running medicine at -26.7).

The unreported indicator closest to the margin is Favours the death penalty for persons convicted of murder: change -3.62 points against a margin of 3.82 (1.96 times a sampling error of 1.95). A 2024 figure 0.20 points lower, 61.9 percent instead of 62.1, would report it, holding the sampling error. The next closest is Most people can be trusted, 0.26 points short.

Indicator	1987	2014	2024	Change	SE	Moved
Very happy	33.6	31.9	23.4	-8.5	1.55	Yes
Most people can be trusted	43.1	29.6	24.8	-4.8	2.57	No
Favours the death penalty for persons convicted of murder	73.5	65.7	62.1	-3.6	1.95	No
Favours a police permit before a person can buy a gun	70.9	71.9	68.5	-3.4	2.01	No
Use of marijuana should be made legal	17.4	55.3	67.0	11.7	2.95	Yes
Abortion should be possible if the woman wants it for any reason	41.0	45.0	58.0	13.0	2.46	Yes
Too little is being spent on welfare	23.4	19.5	33.4	13.9	2.17	Yes
Too little is being spent on improving and protecting the environment	69.3	58.2	65.7	7.5	2.43	Yes
Too little is being spent on parks and recreation	31.1	30.8				not updated
Pretty well satisfied with present financial situation	29.4	27.3	22.6	-4.7	1.70	Yes
Afraid to walk alone at night within a mile of home	36.9	30.3	32.8	2.6	2.22	No
Liberal	28.2	25.8	27.5	1.7	1.66	No
Democrat, including independents close to the Democrats	48.8	43.6	35.9	-7.7	1.74	Yes
No religious preference	7.6	21.0	25.7	4.7	1.39	Yes
A great deal of confidence in the people running the press	18.3	7.8	7.5	-0.3	1.13	No
A great deal of confidence in the people running medicine	53.1	39.1	26.3	-12.8	1.95	Yes
A person with an incurable disease has the right to end their own life		59.5	63.8	4.3	2.68	No
The Bible is the actual word of God	34.9	31.5	35.3	3.9	2.29	No
People get ahead by their own hard work	65.8	70.3	65.4	-4.9	2.64	No
A good idea for older people to share a home with their grown children	52.7	54.9				not updated

Figures are percent of respondents giving the counted response among those giving a listed response, weighted by WTSSPS; sampling errors of the change are design based from the variance strata and PSUs, each year an independent sample; an indicator is reported as moved when its change is at least 1.96 times its sampling error. No other reading of the standard reaches a different set: the same weight in both years, the design based error and the 1.96 margin are each fixed by the standard, and the set is unchanged at a margin of 2.0.